



EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE  
**Stress Triggers**

# Stress Triggers

---

13%

of people experience challenges  
identifying their stress triggers

---

94%

of people with **high levels** of  
resilience can effectively  
identify their stress triggers

84%

of people with **average levels** of  
resilience can effectively identify  
their stress triggers

64%

of people with **low levels** of  
resilience can effectively  
identify their stress triggers



# Stress Triggers



What are  
your fears or  
phobias?





# How do you feel when exposed to one of your fears?

## VISION CAN BECOME MORE ACUTE

So that you are more attuned to danger. May experience tunnel vision or sharper vision.

## DRY MOUTH

The digestive system shuts down as energy is diverted to the muscles.

## HEART BEATS FASTER

Pumping more blood to the muscles.

## RELEASE OF ADRENALINE

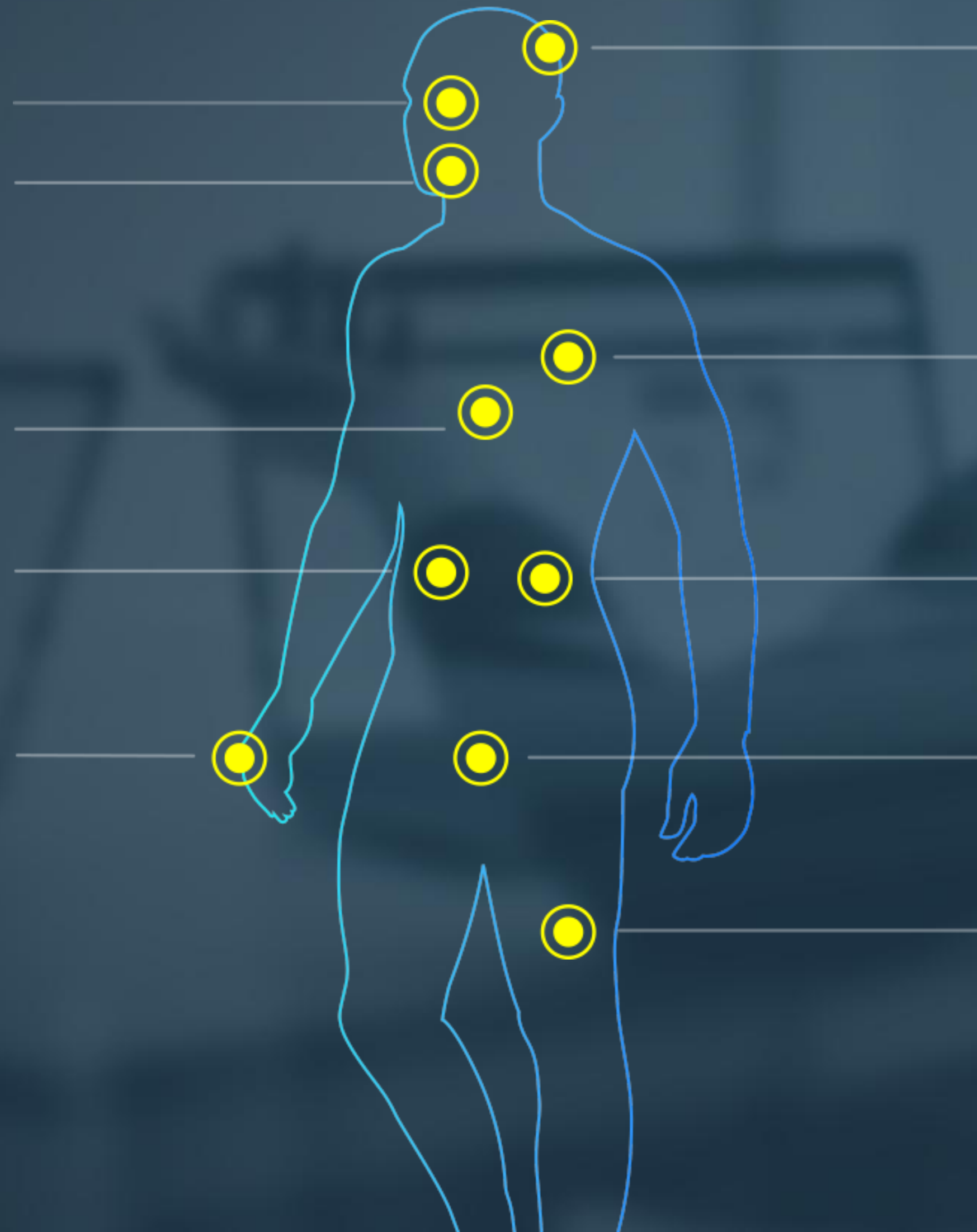
Adrenal glands release adrenaline, signalling the body to respond to danger.

## HANDS GET COLD

As blood vessels in the skin contract, forcing blood to other vessels.

## PALMS BECOME SWEATY

Triggered by the sympathetic nervous system, to keep the body cool.



## RACING THOUGHTS

It can be very difficult to focus on anything other than the perceived danger.

## DIZZY OR LIGHT-HEADED

If we don't use up the extra oxygen.

## FAST, SHALLOW BREATHING

Breathing becomes quicker and shallower.

## NAUSEA AND BUTTERFLIES

In the stomach as blood is diverted away from the digestive system.

## BLADDER URGENCY

Muscles in the bladder can sometimes relax in cases of extreme stress.

## MUSCLES TENSE

In preparation for a potential fight or escape. Muscles may tremble or shake if you stay still as a way of readying for action.

# Stress Triggers in The Work Environment

- Being treated unfairly
- Being unappreciated
- Not being listened to or heard
- Being held to unrealistic deadlines
- Lack of Psychological safety
- Isolation
- Threat of redundancy
- Restructure or acquisition
- Imposter syndrome
- Heavy workload
- Bullying
- Discrimination
- Changes within the organisation
- Changes to role / responsibilities
- Public speaking/presenting
- Job insecurity
- Lack of autonomy



# Fight or Flight



Early humans were exposed to the constant threat of being killed or injured by wild animals or other tribes.



The 'fight or flight' response evolved to increase chances of survival.



It's an automatic response to danger that allows you to react quickly without thinking.



When you feel under threat, the brain automatically activates the 'fight or flight' response by sending signals to release stress hormones that prepare the body to fight or run away.



The response is triggered by emotions such as fear, anxiety, aggression and anger.

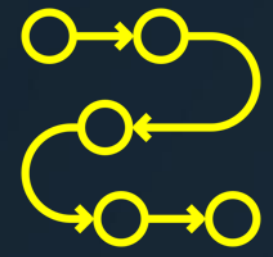


## FIGHT OR FLIGHT IN TODAY'S CLIMATE

Today, there are fewer physical threats but there are more psychological threats, caused by the pressures and stresses of everyday modern life.



# Emotional Hijacking



The amygdala is the part of the brain where emotions are interpreted, regulated and memorised.



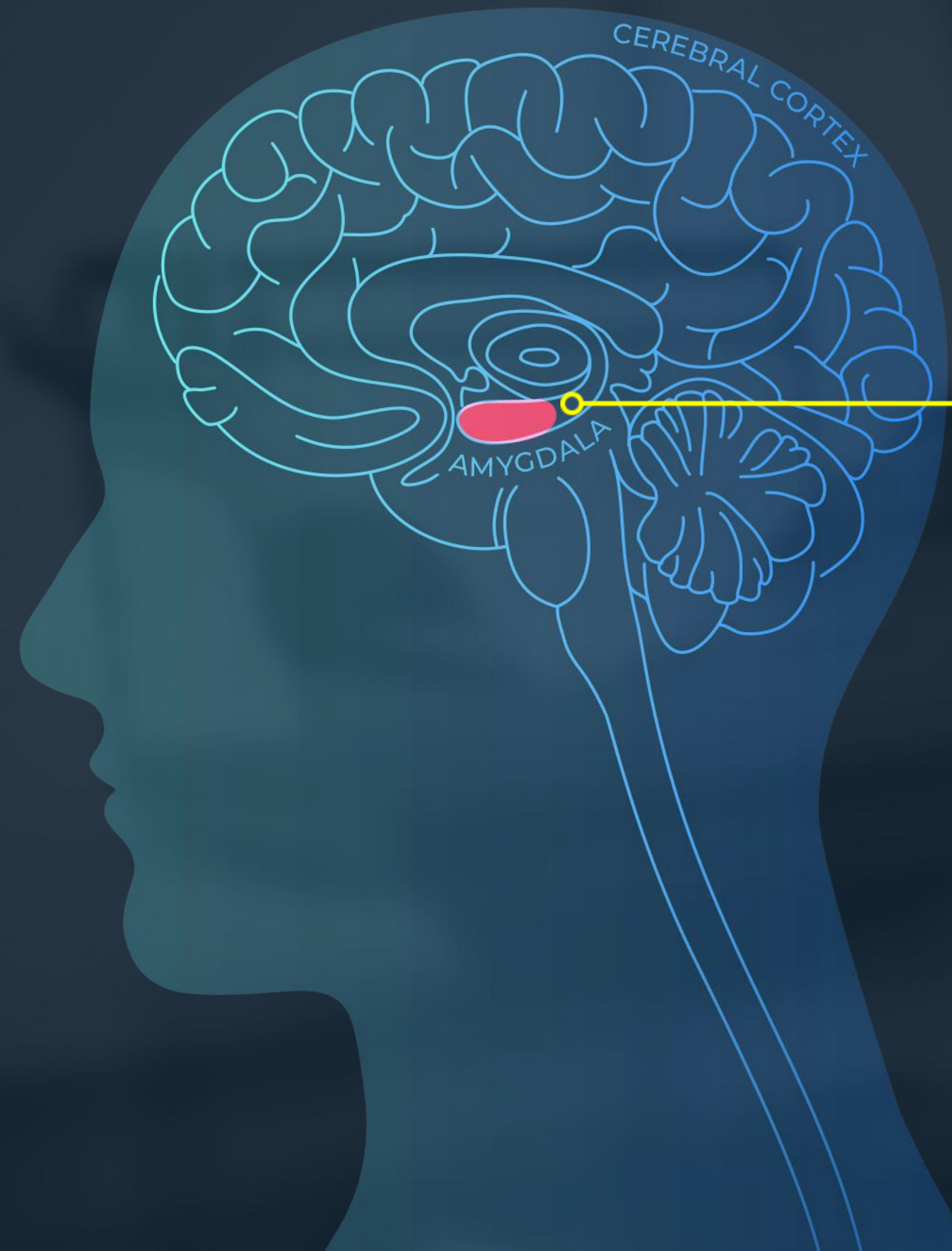
The amygdala is responsible for regulating the 'fight or flight' response.



When we sense imminent danger, the amygdala sends a signal, triggering a release of stress hormones which can help us in survival situations.



In today's climate the emotions which are most likely to trigger the amygdala are anxiety, stress, fear, anger and aggression.

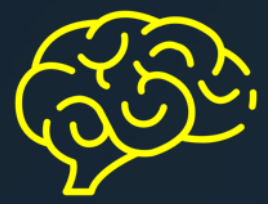


## LOW EMOTION CALM AND RELAXED

The Amygdala doesn't perceive a threat, the cerebral cortex functions normally.



# Emotional Hijacking



The cerebral cortex is where our brain processes information and makes logical decisions. If a threat is mild or moderate it continues to operate as normal.



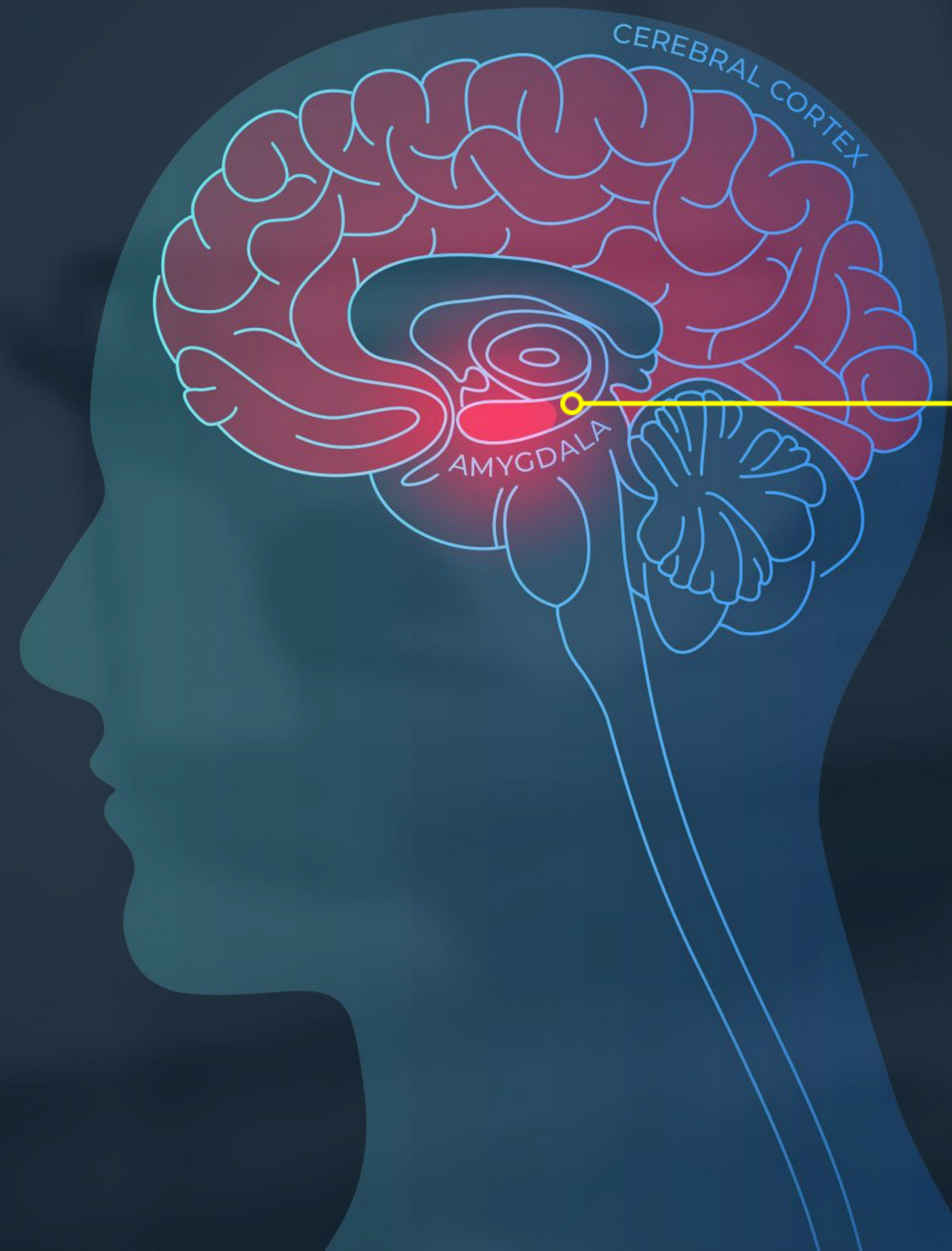
During emotional hijacking, the amygdala disables the cerebral cortex of the brain, hindering our ability to make rational decisions.



With the cerebral cortex disabled, it is difficult to think clearly and control our responses.



An emotional hijack often triggers a sudden, illogical and irrational reaction to a situation, which may be regretted later.

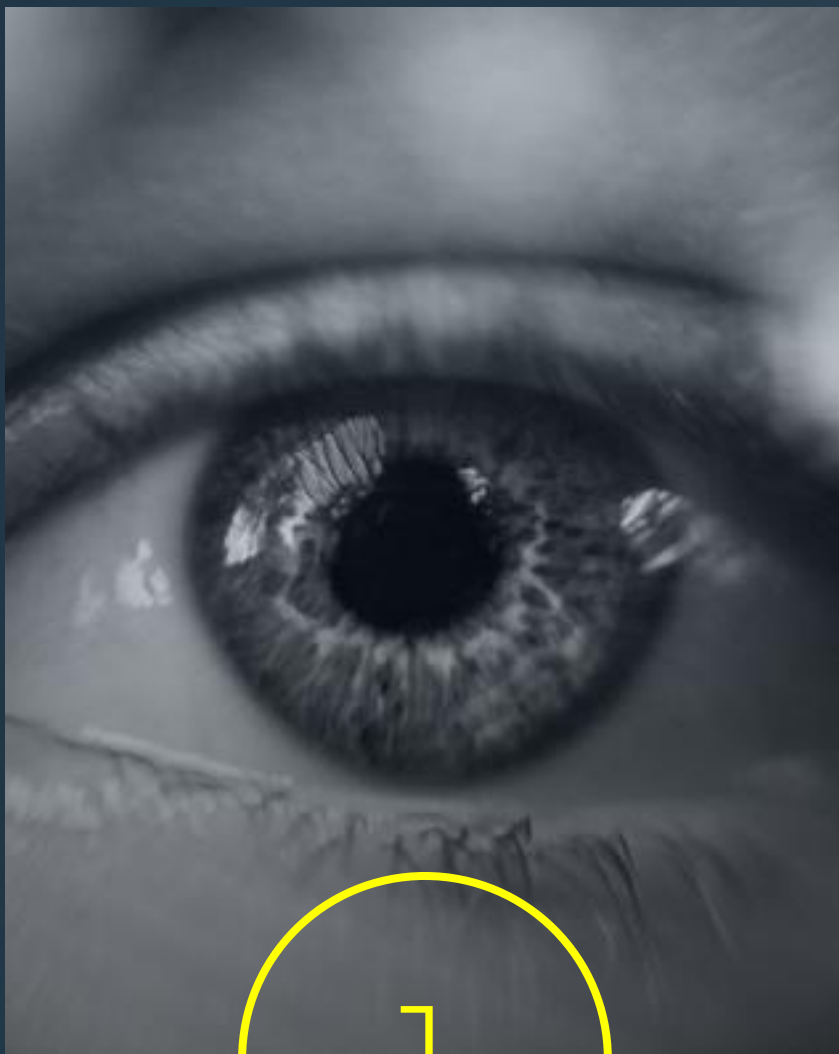


**HIGH EMOTION**  
ANGRY, AFRAID,  
EXCITED

The amygdala triggers the fight or flight response and the cerebral cortex is temporarily disabled.



# Reduce the Impact of an Emotional Hijack



1

## ACKNOWLEDGE

Acknowledge that you feel threatened or stressed and that your fight-flight response has been activated.



2

## CONTROL

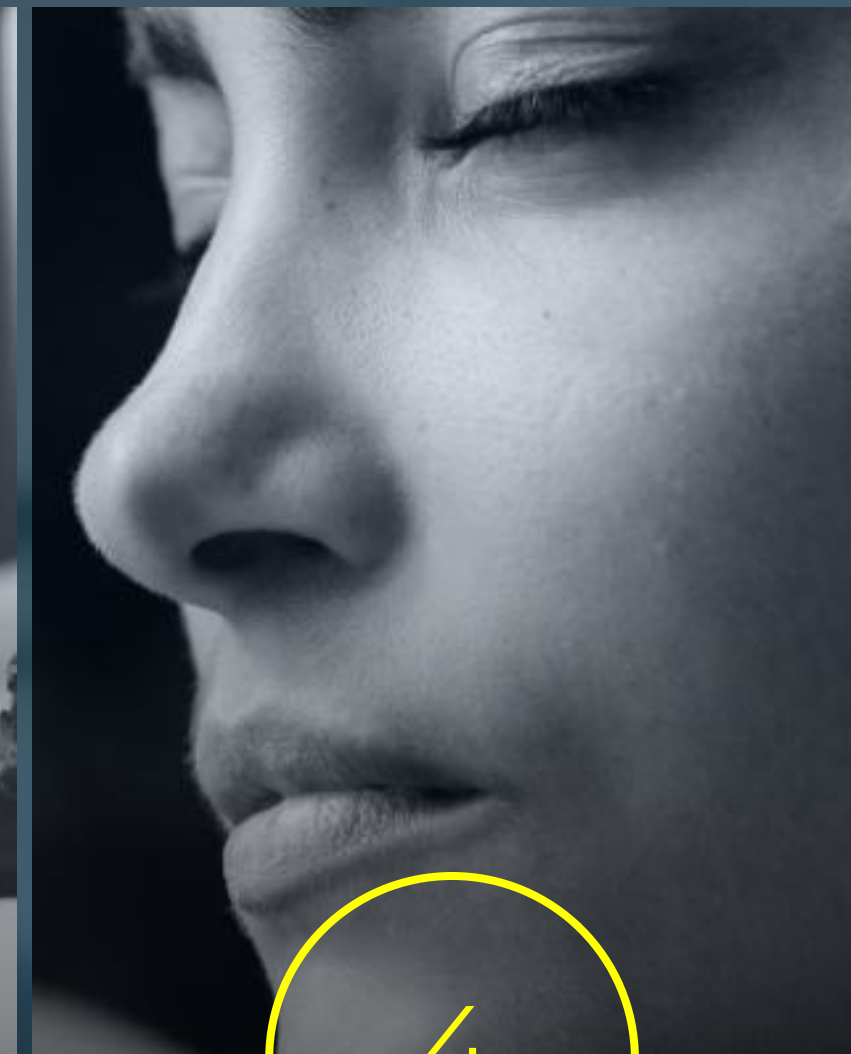
Calm down and take control once the fight-flight response has been activated. Remind yourself that what you are feeling is an automatic response and not necessarily the best or most logical option.



3

## PAUSE

Hit the pause button (wait 6 seconds before responding) and change your environment. This will make your brain reactivate some of the pathways it shut down to handle the hijack.



4

## BREATHE

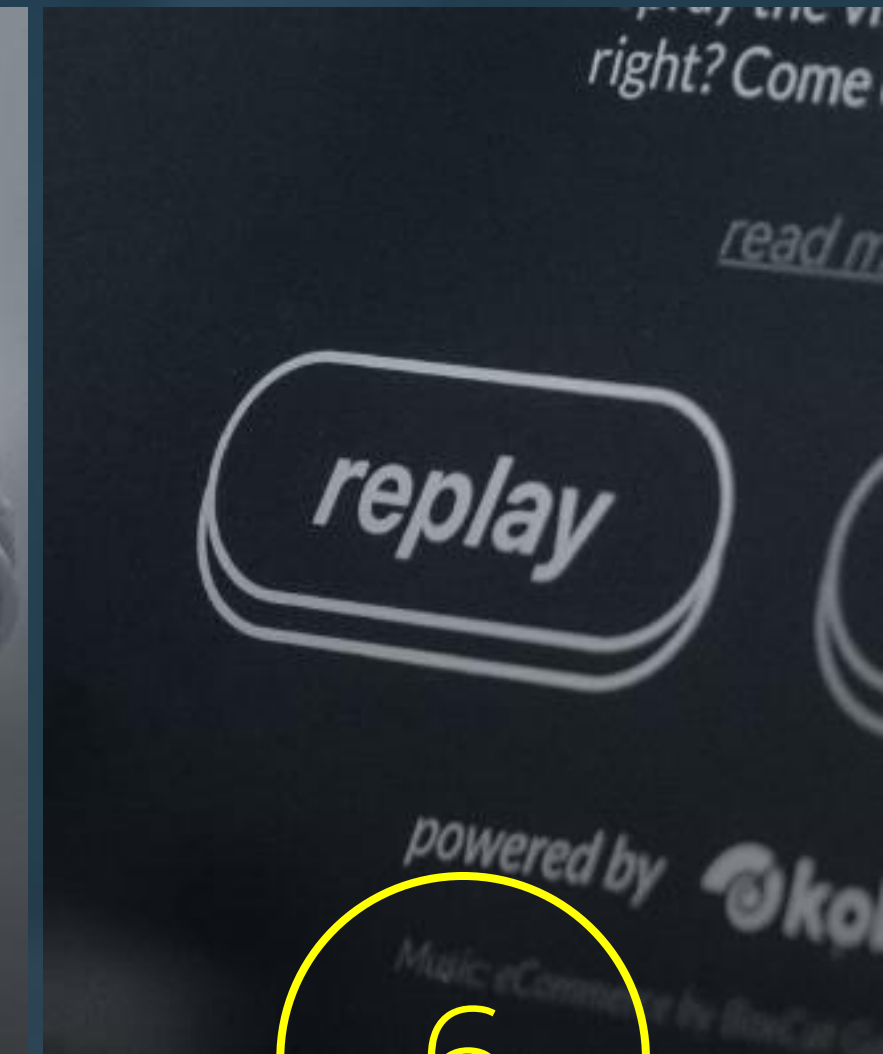
Take a deep breath and pay attention to your breathing. Breathe slowly and evenly and focus on what's going on in your body as you inhale and exhale.



5

## THINK

When calm, consciously engage your higher cortex by thinking about the situation and finding a thoughtful rational solution, making a considered choice.



6

## REVIEW

Become aware of how your emotions and body react to significant stress by reviewing an episode after it's over and label the trigger for the future.



# Avoiding an Emotional Hijack

## IDENTIFY WHAT TRIGGERS A HIJACK FOR YOU



If you are experiencing symptoms of stress you may have been triggered. Think about what may have caused it.



When you feel threatened or afraid, pause and observe any changes in your body and behaviour. Remember these changes, they are warning signs that you are being triggered.



Anything that causes emotional, physical or mental stress can be a trigger.

The key to avoiding an emotional hijack is to diffuse an emotional reaction before it occurs.



## EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE

People with emotional intelligence have a strong connection between the emotional and thinking centres of the brain, allowing them to be aware of their emotions and better control them. To develop your emotional intelligence you must engage with your emotions by recognising, understanding and managing them.



## MINDFULNESS

Mindfulness is one tool you can use to help develop your emotional intelligence. Mindfulness involves staying in the present and being aware of stimuli in your environment, your bodily sensations and what you are thinking and feeling.



# Stress Triggers – Best Practice



Identify the things which cause you the most stress in your life.



Think about how you can avoid or mitigate them going forward.



Be conscious of the physical changes you may start to feel before an emotional hijack.



Pause, take a time out, walk away before reacting to give time for the logical part of your brain to come back online.



# Managing Stress



What are the helpful coping strategies you employ to reduce levels of stress?



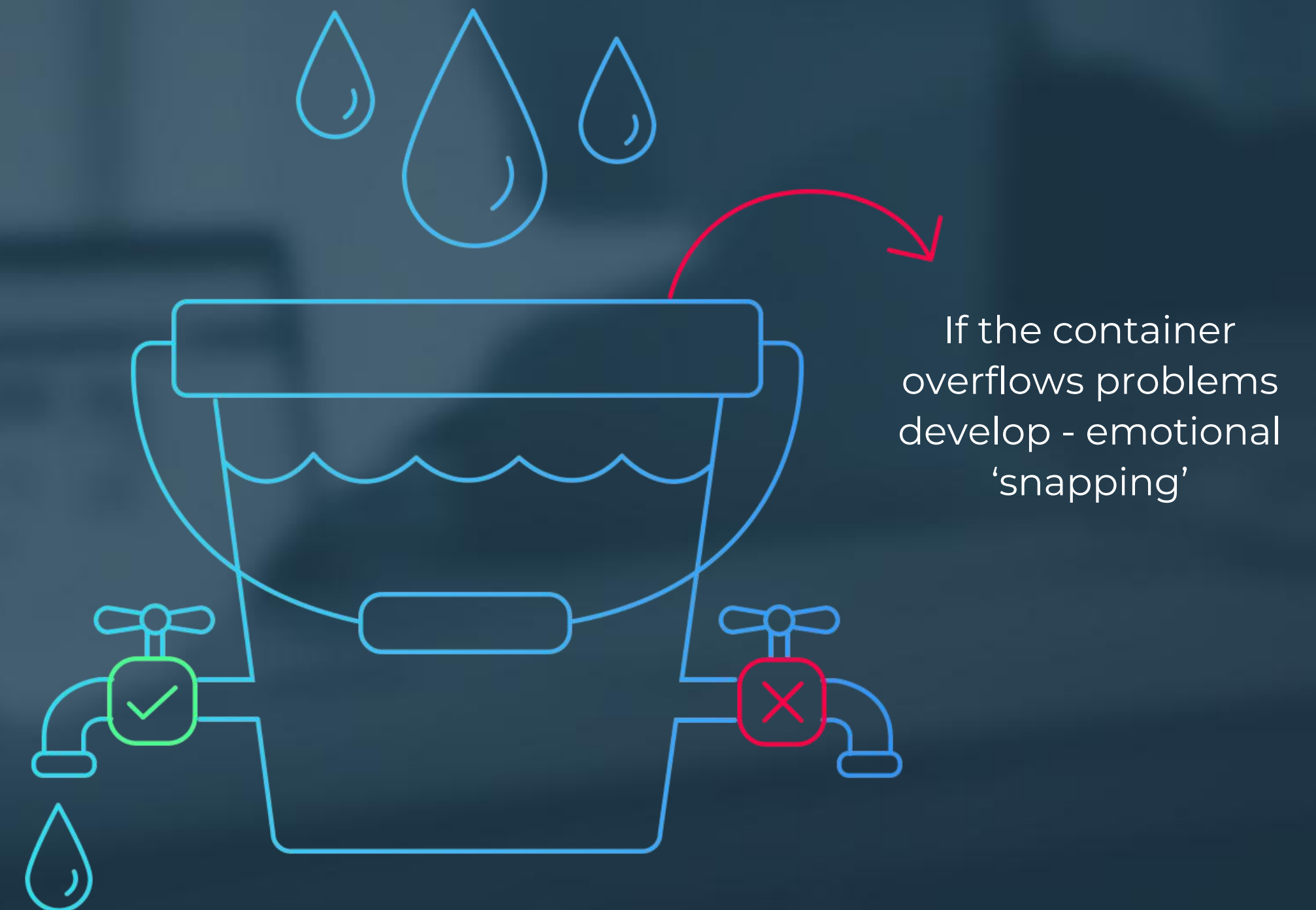
What are the unhelpful coping strategies that you sometimes follow in times of stress?



What typically happens when your stress container overflows?

## The Stress Container

Stress flows into your container  
Vulnerability is defined by the size of the container



### HELPFUL COPING STRATEGIES

The tap will work and reduce levels of stress

### UNHELPFUL COPING STRATEGIES

The tap will be blocked and stress will overflow